

Occupation-Specific Skills, Labor Market Context, and Preferences for Redistribution

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Understanding who supports income redistribution and when is at the core of political economy literature. Nevertheless, even though social stratification literature understands skill specificity as a key element of social class, there are contradictory views on the role it plays in shaping political preferences. I elaborate a framework that provides an understanding of these contradictions. I argue that the effects of occupation-specific skills on redistribution preferences are moderated by the occupational context, being more negative the tighter the occupational labor market is. I propose two mechanisms related to labor market prospects to explain this relationship: occupational expected wages and risk exposure. Using data from the European Social Survey, the International Social Survey Programme, and flexible interactive effects models, I show the relevance of this new approach. This analysis contributes to a more nuanced understanding of the heterogeneity of middle-class political attitudes.

Why is there broad support for the welfare state in some cases, whereas, in others, different social classes exhibit stark differences in political positions? Under what conditions do skills translate into political preferences? These questions are fundamental because the policies that make up the welfare state require broad political support (Rehm 2011). However, although social stratification literature has identified specific skills as a crucial component of social class (e.g., Goldthorpe 2000), there is still disagreement about how they affect redistribution preferences. On the one hand, political economists have long argued that individuals with relatively more specific skills are exposed to greater labor market risks because these skills are less portable compared with general skills (Iversen and Soskice 2001; Pardos-Prado and Xena 2019). On the other hand, political sociology asserts that the probability of job loss decreases with a greater amount of specific skills because they increase replacement costs for firms (Emmenegger 2009).

This article combines social stratification and comparative political economy to shed light on the relationship between specific skills and redistribution preferences. Drawing

on social mobility and insurance literatures (Benabou and Ok 2001; Rehm 2009; Rueda and Stegmueller 2019), the central argument of this article is that the effect of occupation-specific skills (OSSs) on redistribution preferences is moderated by the occupational context. In short, the argument is as follows: when the occupational labor market is tight—that is, when the demand for given occupational skills is similar to or larger than its supply—OSSs are portable and increase replaceability costs for firms. Similar to Goldthorpe’s replaceability thesis, occupations with higher amounts of OSSs exhibit less redistribution support. Conversely, when there is slack in the labor market—that is, the supply of skills is larger than the demand—firms can replace workers more easily, and the lack of portability of skills becomes more important (Huckfeldt 2022; Modestino, Shoag, and Balance 2020). This weakens the negative relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences. The underlying mechanisms driving this relationship are risk exposure, defined as the probability of job loss and its consequences, and occupation-specific expected wage, which is the individual’s future wage profile in the case of remaining employed in the same occupation.¹

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Replication files are available in the *JOP* Dataverse (<https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/jop>). The empirical analysis has been successfully replicated by the *JOP* replication analyst. An online appendix with supplementary material is available at <https://doi.org/10.1086/736340>.

1. Throughout the article, for simplicity, I will refer to this simply as occupational expected wage.

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Although many accounts associate various occupational dimensions with redistribution preferences, and several have explored the role of general skills, there is a striking absence of research that considers the interaction between the amount of occupational skills and the occupational labor market contexts. This gap in the literature stems from overlooking certain elements related to the role of specific skills in labor market prospects. First, there has been a failure to reconcile the different strands of the literature. I argue for a synthesis of the two approaches—that is, the approach that emphasizes that specific skills make workers less replaceable and the approach that highlights that these skills are less portable. Second, there is ambiguity as to whether the authors focus on the relative or absolute level of skill specificity and the meaning of holding greater specific skills.² In this article, following Emmenegger (2009), I examine the role of the absolute amount of specific skills, which better aligns with the vertical dimension of social class (Goldthorpe 2000). Finally, the extent to which skills are specific to a company, industry, or occupation is also unclear (Iversen and Soskice 2001, 857). Drawing on labor economics literature, I focus on OSSs, which are considered crucial for labor market prospects (Jäger and Heining 2022; Kambourov and Manovskii 2009a; Shaw 1984).

The argument has important implications for understanding how skills are related to redistribution preference as well as for research on the roots of the political preferences of different social classes. In particular, it adds to existing studies examining the heterogeneity in preferences of the so-called “middle class.” Although there are explanations based on horizontal dimensions of occupations and focus on work logics (Ares 2020; Kitschelt and Rehm 2014; Oesch 2006), this article draws on political economy literature to provide a self-interested explanation grounded in the vertical dimensions of social class (Häusermann, Kurer, and Schwander 2015; Rueda and Stegmüller 2019). Rather than understanding vertical class position as static, the argument focuses on a key element of employment relations, namely OSSs, and shows how and when these influence political preferences.

In this sense, it complements a recent line of research that contends that highly skilled workers are no longer sheltered from labor market risks (Häusermann et al. 2015; Webb 2019; Wren and Rehm 2014). In fact, research combining data on job tasks and patents shows that artificial intelligence mainly impacts skilled workers (Webb 2019). Acknowledg-

ing the impact of occupational changes on skilled workers, this article focuses on how the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences varies across different occupational contexts. The argument is elaborated to explain redistribution preferences, which are an important determinant of voting decisions (Rueda and Stegmüller 2019).

THE ARGUMENT

This article draws on the literature that emphasizes the importance of social mobility and insurance motives in explaining redistribution preferences. Surprisingly, there is a notable lack of research studying how the interaction between occupational context and occupational skills explains redistribution preferences. To fill this gap, this article proposes a new framework rooted in labor literature. Specifically, occupational skills and occupational context are linked to explain two key dimensions of redistribution preferences: risk exposure and occupational expected wages. This section wraps up by considering how this new framework relates to other arguments linking specific skills and redistribution preferences.

SOCIAL MOBILITY, INSURANCE, AND REDISTRIBUTION PREFERENCES

Economists and political scientists have long stressed the role of self-interest in explaining redistribution preferences with early accounts focusing primarily on individuals' current income (e.g., Meltzer and Richard 1981). Over time, the literature has moved beyond this static framework to examine how individuals' income prospects influence policy preferences, analyzing social insurance (Moene and Wallerstein 2001; Rehm 2009; Varian 1980) and social mobility motives (Alesina and La Ferrara 2005; Benabou and Ok 2001).

Scholars who study insurance preferences argue that individuals cannot accurately predict their future income and, therefore, support measures that reduce income uncertainty and limit the probability of experiencing downward mobility (Rehm 2009). Without such interventions, individuals would over-save, potentially resulting in inefficient outcomes (Varian 1980). These scholars assert that the greater the risk exposure, the greater the support for insurance policies (Iversen and Soskice 2001; Pahontu 2022; Rehm 2009).

In this regard, occupations have been shown to play a crucial role in labor market risks and redistribution preferences (Kambourov and Manovskii 2009b; Rehm 2009; Thewissen and Rueda 2019). Rehm (2009) argues and empirically finds that individuals in occupations with higher unemployment rates tend to demand more redistribution. He also shows that they find it more likely to become unemployed in the near future (Rehm 2016), suggesting that the insurance mechanism is at play. Along similar lines, another stream of

2. For instance, Pardos-Prado and Xena (2019) follow Iversen and Soskice's (2001) relative skill specificity argument to stress the lack of portability of specific skills. However, they define them as “high investments in human capital” (Pardos-Prado and Xena 2019, 287), thus offering an absolute definition of skill specificity.

research examines how recent occupational transformations, driven for instance by automation, may influence redistribution preferences (Gallego et al. 2022; Thewissen and Rueda 2019). Thewissen and Rueda (2019) finds that individuals in occupations requiring more routine tasks tend to support higher levels of redistribution, and Gallego et al. (2022) show that automation risk heightens preferences for slowing technological change, although not necessarily for compensatory policies. However, this body of literature does not directly address the impact of occupational skill levels.

Filling this gap, several articles have attempted to establish a link between skills and occupational risks to explain redistribution preferences, but consensus remains elusive. Häusermann et al. (2015) claim that high-skilled workers are not sheltered from labor market risks and expect them to show a stronger response to an increase in labor market vulnerability compared with low-skilled workers. This is because low-skilled workers already support a high level of redistribution. In contrast, Wren and Rehm (2014) contend that high-skilled workers exposed to international competition are more fearful of becoming unemployed but exhibit lower redistribution preferences. The reason for this is that an increase in social spending can reduce competitiveness, which would further increase the risk of unemployment. In contrast to the approach of this article, these accounts define skill levels as the amount of general skills without considering their occupational dimension.

Furthermore, a common limitation of social insurance literature is its exclusive focus on risk. Beyond insurance motives, some scholars focus more broadly on expected life-cycle income profiles and examine how mobility expectations influence support for redistribution (Alesina and La Ferrara 2005; Benabou and Ok 2001; Rueda and Stegmueller 2019). In line with scholars focusing on risk, social mobility accounts acknowledge that current economic circumstances do not necessarily determine future income streams, prompting individuals to consider their potential future position on the income ladder when forming redistribution preferences. However, they not only consider risk exposure but other dimensions of income prospects, such as the probability of experiencing upward mobility (Benabou and Ok 2001). This literature finds that individuals with greater upward mobility prospects, holding present income constant, are less likely to support redistribution (Alesina and La Ferrara 2005; Rueda and Stegmueller 2019). A limitation of this research is that it overlooks the role played by occupational context and occupational skills (Kambourov and Manovskii 2009b; Lazear 1995).

As Rueda and Stegmueller (2019) point out, social mobility and insurance considerations can be included in an expected (or lifetime) income framework. However, it is

important to distinguish analytically between social mobility and insurance for two important reasons. First, as mentioned above, certain aspects of social mobility—such as upward mobility—are not directly linked to risk exposure. Second, the mechanisms by which they influence political preferences differ. Although theories that focus on risk exposure need to assume loss- or risk-averse individuals to explain preferences (Iversen and Soskice 2001), social mobility arguments do not (Alesina and La Ferrara 2005). With this distinction in mind, the effects proposed in this article focus on two crucial aspects of expected income: (1) the expected steepness of the wage profile, assuming continuous employment in the same occupation (expected occupational wage), and (2) the probability and associated costs of job loss (risk exposure). The first aspect reflects the potential for upward mobility, whereas the second captures the uncertainty of future income and the risk of income loss.

THE ROLE OF OSSs AND LABOR MARKET CONTEXT

The preceding discussion has highlighted a gap in the literature examining the relationship between occupational risks and redistribution preferences. In this section, I delve into the underlying relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences in different occupational contexts. First, I provide a definition of OSSs. Building on this conceptual framework, I then theorize how OSSs are related to redistribution preferences. Consistent with the empirical approach, I compare individuals with similar current income levels, focusing solely on how OSSs influence redistribution preferences by affecting risk exposure and occupational expected wages.³

Although the level at which skills are specific is sometimes ambiguous in the literature, I follow recent developments in labor economics that underscore the importance of occupations in shaping workers' labor market prospects (Huckfeldt 2022; Jäger and Heining 2022; Kambourov and Manovskii 2009b; Shaw 1984). For example, Jäger and Heining (2022) leverage the unexpected death of workers to demonstrate a causal increase in the wages of incumbent workers in the same occupation as the deceased, reflecting the challenge for firms to replace workers with OSSs. Similarly, drawing on the seminal work of Shaw (1984), it was found that workers who change occupations suffer an 18% decrease in wages five years after displacement (Kambourov and Manovskii 2009b), and the effect is particularly pronounced in occupations that

3. In app. A.1, I develop a formal model with loss-averse individuals in which occupational expected wages, the probability of working in a given occupation, and the probability of being unemployed depend on OSSs and the occupational context.

require significant investment in specific human capital (Zangelidis 2008).⁴

In this sense, the definition of occupational skills differs from the accounts that equate the specificity of skills with the demand for those skills. In these settings, the specificity of skills increases as the labor market becomes thinner (Bisbee and Rosendorff 2024; Lazear 2009). In contrast, this article defines OSSs as skills that only enhance productivity in a given occupation, with higher OSSs indicating a greater accumulation of these skills (Becker 1993; Shaw 1984).

Drawing from labor literature, I argue that in tight occupational contexts firms encounter challenges in finding workers with the right skills (Jäger and Heining 2022; Modestino et al. 2020). Therefore, a higher accumulation of OSSs increases the difficulty of replacing workers, as this entails higher training costs for firms (Goldthorpe 2000). Furthermore, OSSs are relatively portable in such contexts because workers are likely to find a job in the same occupation, thereby mitigating the consequences of a possible dismissal. Because replaceability, but not portability, is important, this is similar to Goldthorpe's replaceability thesis, which implies that higher OSSs lead to diminished preferences for redistribution (Emmenegger 2009).

Given the focus on absolute OSSs, it is essential to examine not only income uncertainty but also how OSSs influence wage profiles. Sociological accounts argue that companies, to foster long-term relationships with their employees, offer a pay structure that rises with tenure (Emmenegger 2009; Goldthorpe 2000). As firms may face problems replacing workers with specific skills, contracts that involve specific skills typically yield steeper wage profiles than those involving general skills, and both workers and firms derive some benefit from investing in these skills (Goldthorpe 2000; Lazear 1995). Therefore, OSSs will be positively associated with the steepness of wage profiles in the case of remaining employed in the same occupation (i.e., occupational expected wages).⁵

Building on the rent-sharing and wage-bargaining literature, I contend that the effects of OSSs on future wages in a

given firm depend on the relative bargaining power of workers (Cahuc, Postel-Vinay, and Robin 2006; Jarosch 2023). A corollary of the previous discussion is that the greater the slack in the occupational labor market, the weaker the bargaining power of workers relative to firms (Jarosch 2023), and, therefore, the relationship between OSSs and occupational expected wages is less positive. Thus, according to social mobility accounts, the greater the slack in the labor market, the less negative the impact of OSSs on redistribution preferences, as the prospects of upward mobility are lower.

Certainly, the dynamics within firms are multifaceted, and a variety of factors influence the attachment between firms and employees. Indeed, in situations wherein there is interdependence between firms and workers, replaceability motives may not be determined by occupational labor markets (Lazear 2009; Tåhlin 2007). For example, this could be the case for managers (Jäger and Heining 2022). However, even in such scenarios, the occupational context determines the external options for workers, which are, by definition, independent of their relationship with the firm. If the occupational context deteriorates, the worker and the firm know that the use of OSSs outside the current workplace becomes more difficult, which harms the bargaining power of workers vis-à-vis firms.

Moreover, it should be acknowledged that not only skills play a role in explaining redistribution preferences. As is widely recognized in the literature, technological progress is an important determinant of political preferences (Gallego et al. 2022; Thewissen and Rueda 2019). However, exposure to technological developments and OSSs are theoretically and empirically different. Whereas exposure to technological change is primarily concerned with how particular technologies complement or substitute certain tasks, the argument proposed here relates to the amount of skills required to perform a job. Indeed, technological change affects different occupational skill groups in different ways. For example, information technology impacts occupations that perform routine tasks that tend to be in the middle of the skills ladder (Thewissen and Rueda 2019), whereas artificial intelligence affects occupations that involve judgment and optimization and that require a higher level of specialized training (Webb 2019, 3).

SPECIFIC SKILLS AND REDISTRIBUTION PREFERENCES: COMPETING ARGUMENTS

Does this new argument improve our understanding of how specific skills relate to redistribution preferences? Are the implications of the model different from those put forth by previous studies? To answer these questions, this section compares the proposed approach to the portability argument of Iversen and Soskice (2001) and the replaceability

4. These effects are, for example, three times smaller for the case of firm-specific skills (FSS) (Kambourov and Manovskii 2009b).

5. Because they reflect an individual's foreseen earnings if they remain in the same occupation, occupational expected wages do not mechanically take into account the probability of job loss or its associated consequences. Indeed, these are two independent channels by which OSSs affect redistribution preferences. The formal model in app. A.1 demonstrates how these mechanisms operate separately to shape preferences for redistribution and reveals that loss aversion impacts each mechanism in opposing ways.

argument put forward by sociological accounts (Emmenegger 2009; Goldthorpe 2000).⁶

According to the portability argument, an increase in relative skill specificity leads to greater redistribution preferences, as specific skills are less portable than general skills (Iversen and Soskice 2001; Lamo, Messina, and Wasmer 2011; Pardos-Prado and Xena 2019). An increase in relative skill specificity is defined as the increase in specific skills that maintains an individual's expected income constant. Because specific skills are less portable than general skills, an increase in skill specificity at constant expected income implies greater income uncertainty, fostering redistribution demands (Varian 1980). However, these authors do not take into account the role played by the labor markets or how specific skills may protect workers from job loss (Iversen and Soskice 2001, 880). Indeed, in a related article examining the independent effect of occupational labor market context and skill specificity, the authors assert that "(r)egardless of levels of unemployment – even in your own occupation – specificity of skills limits your re-employment potential" (Cusack, Iversen, and Rehm 2006, 367).

The replaceability argument put forth by sociological accounts offers a contrasting view. They claim that the previous explanation neglects the protective role of specific skills, which make workers more difficult to replace. As a result, they hypothesize that having a greater amount of specific skills increases a worker's labor market security, thereby lowering their preference for risk-reducing policies (Emmenegger 2009). The reason for this is that firms would incur training costs in the case of dismissal (Goldthorpe 2000). In contrast to the previous argument, this one compares individuals with different skill levels and, thus, with different income expectations. Therefore, the impact on policy preferences is expected to occur through two channels: first, by increasing expected wages and, second, by reducing the risk of job loss (Alesina and La Ferrara 2005; Rehm 2009). However, scholars proposing replaceability motives do not systematically consider the role of the labor market context, mainly because of the lack of a clear definition of the level at which skills are considered specific.

Diversely, the model proposed in this article links OSSs to redistribution preferences by combining insights from both perspectives. In a tight occupational labor market, the argument resembles that of replaceability, implying a negative relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences. In this context, the high costs of replacing workers for firms outweigh the fact that OSSs can only be used in a given oc-

cupation, an effect that is reinforced by the fact that the impact of OSSs on occupational expected wages is substantial. However, I argue that the greater the slack in the occupational context, the less negative this relationship becomes. This is because the cost of replacing workers decreases and skills become less portable, a fact that is more harmful the higher the amount of OSSs. These effects are amplified by the lower increase in occupational expected wages.⁷ This discussion of how OSSs affect various components of expected or lifetime income depending on the occupational labor market presents a challenge to conceptualize OSSs in relative terms.

DATA SOURCES AND OPERATIONALIZATION

The main empirical analysis of this article is based on all European Union countries in the first nine rounds of the European Social Survey (ESS), with data from 2002 to 2020, before the COVID pandemic (see app. B.1). The ESS data set stands out for its high quality and, crucially for the purposes of this article, includes a question on redistribution preferences along with comprehensive occupational information. For occupational variables, I use two external data sources. Specifically, I retrieve OSS data from the Programme for the International Assessment of Adult Competencies (PIAAC) and use the Labour Force Surveys (LFSs) provided by Eurostat to capture the occupational context. In addition, I use different rounds of the Role of Government questionnaires of the International Social Survey Programme (ISSP) to analyze specific policy preferences. Because of space limitations, the control variables and data from the ISSP are presented in appendices B.2 and B.5, respectively.

OSS

Political economists and sociologists have operationalized specific skills in different ways. Sociological literature tends to use the Erikson-Goldthorpe-Portocarero class schema (Emmenegger 2009). Conversely, in comparative political economy, Iversen and Soskice's (2001) measure is often used (Gingrich and Ansell 2012; Pardos-Prado and Xena 2019). Specifically, the measure of absolute skill specificity proposed by these authors is proportional to the number of four-digit occupations within each two-digit group in the International Standard Classification of Occupations (ISCO) classifications divided by the proportion of workers in that occupation. The authors consider that an ISCO group containing many occupations indicates either highly specific occupational tasks or a large number of

6. In the formal model in app. A.1, I show how, depending on the assumptions, the different competing explanations arise.

7. However, it should be noted that the theory is agnostic about the sign of the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences at the highest levels of slackness (Berry, Golder, and Milton 2012). Although, in theory, OSS could be positively associated with redistribution preferences in sufficiently slack labor markets, empirical analysis demonstrates otherwise.

workers in that occupation. Hence, by dividing by the share of workers in the occupation, they capture the “degree of specialization.”

However, these variables are not suitable for the analysis undertaken in this article because they do not directly capture how long/costly it is to acquire skills, which is crucial for my argument. To calculate the amount of OSSs, I use the Survey of Adult Skills questionnaire from the PIAAC, which aims to measure cognitive skills that are useful in the workplace. It was carried out by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development in 40 countries between 2011 and 2015.⁸ In this questionnaire, respondents were asked, “supposing that someone with this level of qualification was applying today, how much related work experience would they need to *get* this job?”, coded in months, wherein “this level of qualification” refers to the formal qualifications required to qualify for the job, including internships and work placements.

This question taps into crucial elements of the argument. By asking about “related experience,” it captures how costly it would be for firms to hire another worker without the required skills (replaceability) as well as the experience that would be lost if workers move to another sector in which that experience is not important (portability). Because the question refers to the experience required to “get this job,” it rules out the possibility that this experience was acquired within the company. However, for young workers with little experience, the answers are censored from above, leading the variable to be inherently linked to work experience or age. For this reason, to obtain the occupational dimension of skill specificity, I average answers at the ISCO two-digits level for individuals aged more than 30 years old (specific operationalization and descriptive statistics in app. B.3.1 and B.3.2).⁹

Even not considering young workers, the variable in question may be correlated to confounding factors, such as tenure. In addition, it is crucial to assess whether this variable accurately measures the absolute dimension of skills. To investigate this, figure 1A illustrates the relationship between OSSs and various seniority measures, whereas figure 1B analyzes its relationship to income.¹⁰ They display the nonparametric least-squares binscatter estimates and the associated cubic polynomial fit with the associated 95% confidence intervals

(Cattaneo et al. 2024).¹¹ Because the main specification leverages within the ISCO one-digit variation in OSSs, figure 1 shows the results with and without occupation fixed effects (FEs), in black and gray, respectively.

Figure 1A shows the association between OSSs and age, tenure (from rounds 2 and 5 of the ESS), and potential experience (i.e., age minus education years). It turns out that although there is a positive correlation between OSSs and age or tenure, it fades away when occupation FEs are introduced, the same being true for potential experience. This suggests that the variation in OSSs used in the empirical analysis does not reflect seniority.

Shifting the focus to assess whether the OSSs measure accurately captures the absolute dimension of skills, figure 1B examines its relationship to income. This association is compared with years of education and the absolute skill specificity variable proposed by Iversen and Soskice (2001). Similar to years of education and supporting the notion that the proposed variable captures the absolute dimension of skills, the OSS variable shows a monotonically positive relationship with income for both specifications. However, contrary to the argument put forward by Iversen and Soskice (2001), this is not observed for their measure of absolute skill specificity.

Appendix B.3 contains a more detailed analysis of this variable. Appendix B.3.3 compares it with the absolute specific skill variable proposed by Iversen and Soskice (2001) and with the type of education (either vocational or general). Appendix B.3.4 shows the relationship between OSSs and personal characteristics, such as altruism or the importance given to creativity, as well as the empirical difference with the routinization task index (Thewissen and Rueda 2019).

Occupation unemployment rates

In the theoretical framework, slack occupational labor markets refer to contexts in which the supply of workers with certain occupational skills exceeds the demand for those skills. Although labor economics studies typically operationalize slackness as national unemployment rates (Huckfeldt 2022; Modestino et al. 2020), I focus on slackness at the occupational level. To capture this, I use occupational unemployment rates (OURs), a well-established measure in the political economy literature (Rehm 2009). This variable reflects the conceptual underpinnings of the proposed interactive effect, as it directly reflects the possibility of replacing workers and the difficulty for workers of finding a job in the same occupation in the case of

8. I use all the countries that also appear in my ESS sample; see app. B.1.

9. Specifically, I use ISCO88 and ISCO08 classifications. These classifications have different levels of detail, from one digit (containing 9 occupations) to four digit (containing 390 and 436 occupations, respectively). Crucially, available crosswalks allow homogenizing these classifications, if they are provided in their most detailed form. For this reason, as will be discussed, measures of occupational context can only be calculated separately at the ISCO88 and ISCO08 levels. I measure OSSs accordingly.

10. The variables are defined in app. B.2.

11. In all regressions, country-year FEs are included, population and survey weights are used, and CIs are calculated from standard errors clustered at the country-occupation level.

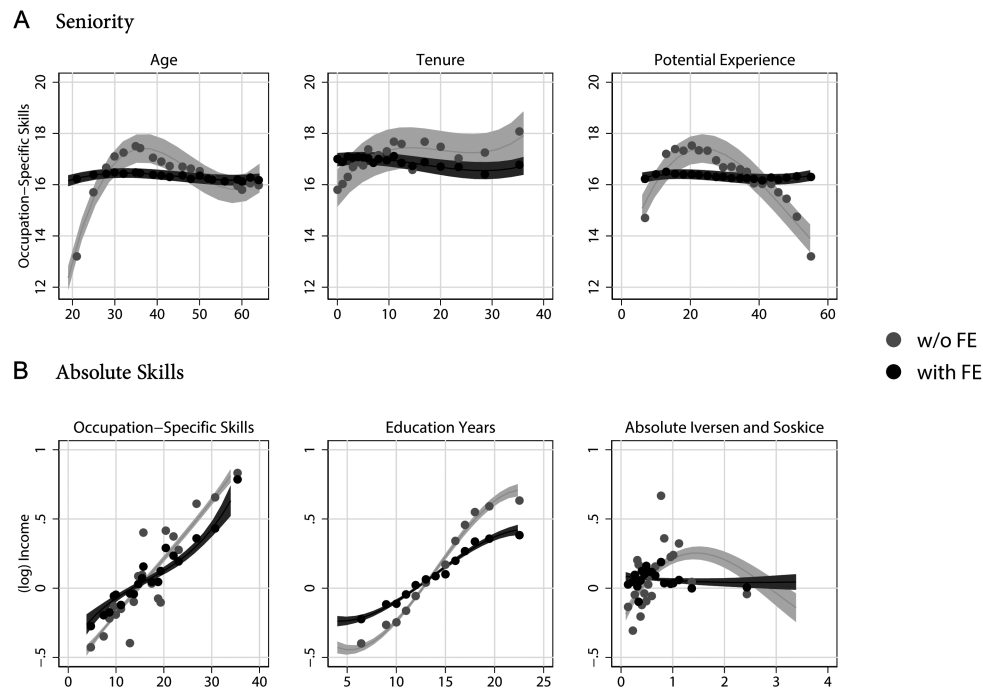


Figure 1. Occupation-specific skills, seniority, and absolute skills: least-squares binscatters. Least-squares binscatter estimates, without (gray) and with (black) occupation FEs, jointly with the cubic fit of the relationship.

job loss (Huckfeldt 2022; Modestino et al. 2020).¹² This variable is calculated as country unemployment rates but at the ISCO two-digit level. To calculate it, I use the Labor Force Surveys provided by Eurostat, which provide sufficiently large samples to compute unemployment rates at this level of disaggregation.¹³

Because testing interactive effects having a skewed moderator can make the results model dependent (Hainmueller, Mummolo, and Xu 2019), I transform the variable. Similar to Rehm (2009), I smooth the series and recode the extreme values by setting the minimum and maximum values to the first and last percentiles of OURs in the sample, respectively. Furthermore, I then take the logarithm to reduce the remaining skewness (the steps of the transformation are explained in detail in app. B.4). Figure 2 displays the histogram of the untransformed OUR variable (A) and the transformed variable (B). To determine whether there might be problems related to severe extrapolation, Hainmueller et al. (2019) suggest examin-

ing whether the L-kurtosis of the moderator is greater than 0.16. For the untransformed variable, the L-kurtosis is 0.21, whereas for the transformed one, it is 0.12. This indicates that the transformed variable is more appropriate.

Redistribution preferences

To capture preferences for redistribution, I use an item from the ESS that presents respondents with the following statement: “the government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels.” This is a Likert item in which respondents have five response options ranging from “strongly agree” to “strongly disagree,” with an intermediate option that is “neither agree nor disagree.” Table 1 displays the distribution of the variable, revealing that approximately 70% of respondents express some degree of support for redistribution. To better interpret the results, in the main analysis I code “agree” or “strongly agree” answers as one and zero otherwise (Rueda and Stegmueller 2019), but the results are robust when using the untransformed version of the variable (see app. D.1).

Figure 3 displays binscatter plots illustrating the raw relationship between redistribution preferences and OSSs in the lowest and highest terciles of OURs. The gray dots represent the average level of redistribution support across different levels of OSSs, whereas the gray lines show the linear fit of a bivariate ordinary least-squares (OLS) regression. Figure 3A illustrates the relationship for major occupational groups using between-occupation variation of OSSs, whereas figure 3B displays the

12. It should be noted that other variables also grasp the occupational context—for instance, capturing robot exposure (e.g., Anelli, Colantone, and Stanig 2021) or occupational job creation. The robustness section shows that the results are not sensitive to using robot exposure and the ratio between job creation and OURs as moderators.

13. LFSs identify occupations at the three-digit ISCO level, using ISCO88 until 2010 and ISCO08 thereafter, which does not allow homogenization at the same ISCO classification. Therefore, I calculate OURs using ISCO88 until 2010 and then using ISCO08 afterward.

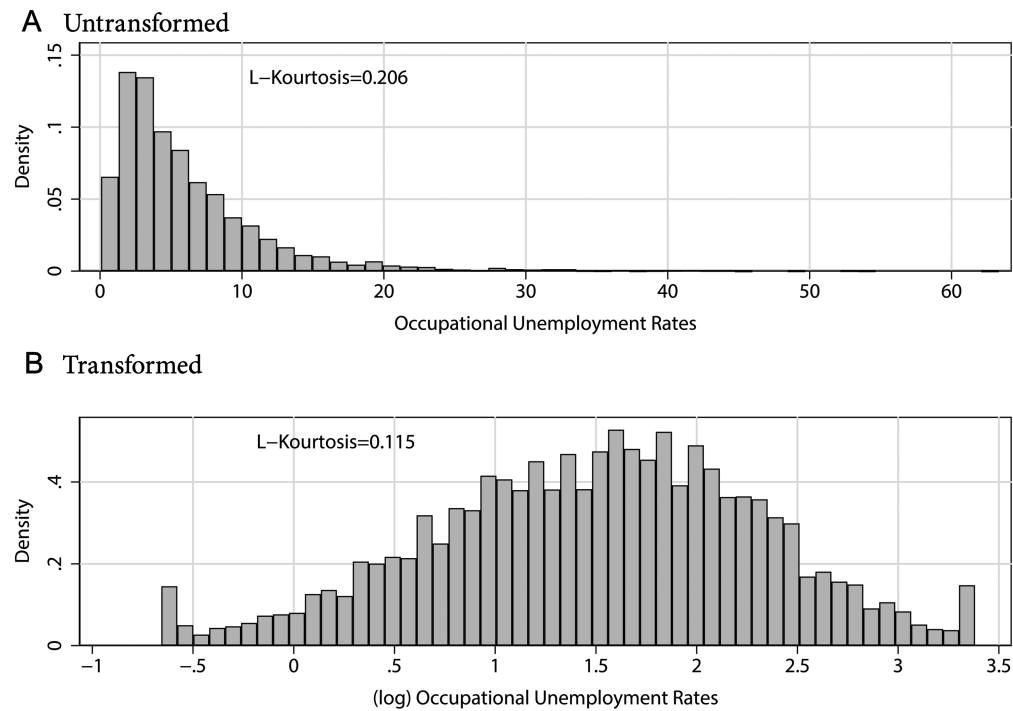


Figure 2. Histogram of occupation unemployment rates and the logarithmic transformation.

relationship examining variations within occupations. In this latter case, darker dots indicate that the major occupational group requires higher amounts of OSSs.

As anticipated, when OURs are low, individuals with higher OSSs tend to exhibit less support for redistribution. Conversely, the relationship weakens significantly when OURs are high, suggesting that there are fewer differences in redistribution preferences between occupations. Consistent with the argument, both the estimated slope of the relationship (b) and the correlation (r) are three to six times higher when OURs are low compared with when they are high. This happens for both analyses.

Because occupation FEs are included, figure 3B only exploits variation in OSSs within major occupations. Comparing the upper and lower panels, one can observe that the variability of OSSs diminishes significantly after the introduction of occupation FEs. Indeed, the standard deviation of OSSs

decreases by 60%. Therefore, explored changes in OSSs as well as counterfactual exercises to assess their substantive importance will consider typical within-occupation variations in OSSs to avoid implausible comparisons (Mummolo and Peterson 2018).

METHODS

Similar to other articles that rely on the occupational dimension of preferences, I analyze changes in the variable of interest that involve comparing individuals with different occupations (Rehm 2009; Thewissen and Rueda 2019; Walter 2017). Usually, the literature asserts that self-selection into occupations due to risk preferences is not very likely and that workers usually do not have free choice when deciding in which occupation to work (Rehm 2016, 41). However, there is evidence casting doubts on this reasoning (Bonin et al. 2007). To alleviate

Table 1. Distribution Redistribution Preferences (in Percentages)

Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neither	Agree	Strongly Agree
2.41	11.36	14.17	43.67	28.39

Note. Data from rounds 1 to 9 of the ESS. Design and population weights applied. $N = 142,439$.

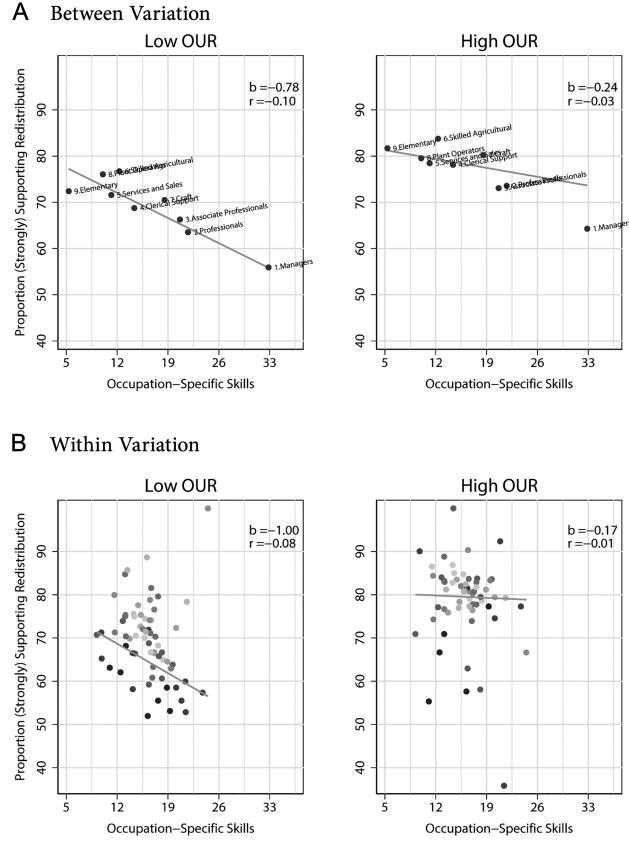


Figure 3. Binscatter and linear relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences. b is the coefficient of regressing redistribution preferences on OSSs, whereas r is the correlation between both variables. The gray line shows the best linear fit between both variables. $N_{Low} = 47,500$ and $N_{High} = 47,477$.

these concerns, the specifications below compare individuals who are in the same ISCO one-digit occupation and have similar observable characteristics (income, age, risk preferences, altruism, etc.) but who are employed in occupations that require different levels of OSSs.

The main thesis of this article is that the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences depends on the occupational labor market context. To perform this analysis, I model redistribution preferences (RED_i) to be a function of OSSs, OURs, and their interaction (as well as a set of covariates).¹⁴ Assuming that the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences is a linear function of the logarithm of OURs:

$$Red_i = \mu + \alpha OSS_o + \eta OUR_{o,c,t} + \beta OSS_o \times OUR_{o,c,t} + \delta' Z_i + \phi_{1o} + \varphi_{c,t} + e_i, \quad (1)$$

14. I assume that redistribution preferences are continuous, an assumption discussed in app. C1.

where o , c , and t should be understood as functions that map individuals, i , into their occupations, countries, and year of the survey, respectively. OSS_o indicates OSSs, and $OUR_{o,c,t}$ is OURs. μ , α , η , β , and δ are the coefficients to be estimated, with α and β being the parameters of interest. From the theoretical discussion, it is expected that the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences is negative at the lowest level of OURs ($\alpha < 0$) but is less so as the OURs become higher ($\beta > 0$).

In terms of covariates, to avoid “omitted interaction bias”, Z_i is made up of controls defined in appendix B.2 and their interaction with OURs (Blackwell and Olson 2022).¹⁵ For instance, female workers tend to be in occupations that require fewer OSSs and may react distinctly to the occupational labor market. Thus, not including the interaction between being female and OURs could lead to classic omitted variable bias. To take into account selection into occupations, which may differ by occupational context, ϕ_{1o} are ISCO one-digit occupation FEs interacted with OURs. Finally, $\varphi_{c,t}$ are country-year FEs that control country-level variables that could affect redistribution preferences, such as institutional variables and national unemployment rates (Ahrens 2024; Gingrich and Ansell 2012). Appendix D.3 discusses and shows the results with different FE structures.

However, although it is common in the literature to assume that the interactive effects are a linear function of the moderator, this specific functional form is not theoretically founded. To deal with this issue, I follow the two approaches proposed by Hainmueller et al. (2019). First, I utilize a binning estimator. Specifically, for each tercile j of OURs, I create a dummy variable $G_{i,j}$ that takes the value of one when the OURs of individual i is in the j -th tercile of OURs and zero otherwise.¹⁶ Then, a model that allows for linear interactive effects within each tercile is regressed. Specifically, the equation to be estimated via OLS is the following:

$$Red_i = \sum_{j=1}^3 \{ \mu_j + \alpha_j OSS_o + \eta_j \ddot{O}UR_{o,c,t} + \beta_j OSS_o \times \ddot{O}UR_{o,c,t} \} G_{i,j} + \delta' Z_i + \phi_{1o} + \varphi_{c,t} + e_i, \quad (2)$$

where $\ddot{O}UR_{o,c,t}$ is the deviation of i 's OURs from their tercile's median. Because of this transformation, the coefficient of α_j gives the effect of OSSs at the median level of the j -th tercile of

15. That is, z_i being the controls included, the estimation takes the following form: $Red_i = \mu + \alpha OSS_o + \eta OUR_{o,c,t} + \beta OSS_o \times OUR_{o,c,t} + \gamma' z_i + \phi' z_i \times OUR_{o,c,t} + \phi_{1o} + \varphi_{c,t} + e_i$. With $\delta Z_i = \gamma z_i + \phi z_i \times OUR_{o,c,t}$.

16. More formally, $t(\cdot)$ being a function that maps individuals into terciles of OURs, $G_{i,j} = 1\{t(i) = j\}$. App. D.5.1 explores what happens when dividing the moderator into quartiles and quintiles.

OURs. Thus, α_1 would be the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences for a typical individual with low OURs. Thus, according to the argument, it is expected that $\alpha_1 < 0$ and that $\alpha_1 < \alpha_2 < \alpha_3$. Importantly, equation 2 is a generalization of the linear interaction model, so it can be tested which of the two models is preferred (Hainmueller et al. 2019, 171). The choice of model is a classic bias-variance trade-off: Because of its flexibility, the binning specification tends to be less biased than the linear model, at the cost of greater variance. I will show the results employing both approaches as well as a test to select the preferred specification.

The second strategy proposed by Hainmueller et al. (2019) is to use a kernel-smoothing estimator that allows marginal effects to vary, almost freely, at all levels of the moderator. Useful for this analysis, this method allows testing at which range of OURs the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences is estimated to be different from zero. Specifically, the specification is the following:

$$\text{Red}_i = f(\text{OUR}_{o,c,t}) + \text{OSS}_o \times g(\text{OUR}_{o,c,t}) + h(\text{OUR}_{o,c,t}) \times z_i + \phi_{1o} + \varphi_{c,t} + e_i, \quad (3)$$

where $g(\cdot)$ is a kernel-smoothing function that captures the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences for distinct values of OURs, and $h(\cdot)$ is a vector of kernel-smoothing functions for distinct controls. From the theoretical discussion, it is expected that $g(\cdot)$ is monotonically increasing in its argument, implying that the larger the OURs, the less negative the effect of OSSs at all levels of occupational context. The critical component of kernel-smoothing estimates is the selection of the bandwidth. I allow greater bandwidths when the density of the moderator is lower and they are selected through 10-fold cross-validation.

RESULTS

Main results

Figure 4 graphically summarizes the main results of the three estimation procedures discussed, with the regressions including all controls, occupation FEs, and country-round FEs (see app. C.2 for the table of coefficients with a different set of controls). Standard errors are allowed to be correlated among individuals working in a given country-occupation. Moreover, design and population weights are applied.

Figure 4A shows the estimated relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences for different levels of OURs from linear and binning regressions. The black line is the estimated change in the probability of supporting redistribution associated with an increase of OSSs of two within-occupation standard deviations. This association is estimated as a linear

function of the logarithm of OURs.¹⁷ The associated 95% confidence intervals are displayed in dark gray. Under this specification, the worse the occupational context, the less negative the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences. It can also be observed that the estimated relationship is negative for most values of OURs. In particular, for the lowest values of OURs, a two-standard deviation increase in OSSs is associated with an average reduction in the probability of supporting redistribution preferences of five percentage points (p.p.), *ceteris paribus*. More importantly, introducing the moderating role of OURs enriches the analysis. Indeed, OSSs and redistribution preferences are conditionally uncorrelated at the highest values of OURs.

In dark gray, the results of the binning regression are displayed. Specifically, they are the coefficients and 95% confidence intervals associated with the median value of each tercile of the moderator.¹⁸ Consistent with my argument, the higher the OURs, the less negative the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences. Indeed, it turns out that for a typical high value of OURs, the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences is very close to zero and not statistically significant at usual levels of confidence. Moreover, the difference between the estimated coefficient at low and high levels of OURs is statistically significant, indicating the existence of an interactive relationship (Hainmueller et al. 2019). As mentioned earlier, the binning estimate is a generalization of the linear interaction model, so it can be tested whether the two models are significantly different. Indeed, the Wald test does not reject the null hypothesis that both models are the same ($p < .008$), indicating that the binning model is more adequate.

Turning to analyze semiparametric estimates, figure 4B displays the results of the kernel-smoothing specification. The adaptive bandwidth for the area with the highest density is 1.199 (selected through 10-fold cross-validation). Overall, the results suggest an interactive relationship, with OSSs being less associated with redistribution preferences the worse the occupational context. At the lowest OURs levels, a two-standard deviation increase in OSSs is associated with a 4-p.p. decrease in the probability of supporting redistribution. In absolute terms, this value drops to around 2.5 p.p. at medium levels of OURs and becomes statistically insignificant at high

17. It has been argued that two standard deviation changes are more meaningful than one standard deviation change, allowing also a better comparison of the effects with binary covariates (Gelman 2008).

18. The terciles are defined as follows. The lowest tercile includes all values between -0.657 and 1.155 , with a median value of 0.681 . The middle tercile includes values greater than 1.155 and lower than 1.878 , with a median of 1.542 . The largest tercile ranges from 1.878 to 3.381 and the median is 2.288 .



Figure 4. Linear, binning, and kernel-smoothing estimates. (A) Estimates of the linear interaction and binning specifications and the associated 95% confidence intervals. (B) Kernel-smoothing estimates and the associated confidence intervals. The optimal bandwidth in the highest density areas, selected via 10-fold cross-validation, is 1.199. Regressions include all controls defined in app. B.2 and occupation FEs, their interaction with occupational unemployment rates, and country-year FEs. Clustered standard errors at country-occupation. Design and population weights applied.

OUR levels. It should be noted that there is no observed value of OUR at which OSSs and redistribution preferences are positively related.

The main takeaway from these analyses is that for low values of OURs, individuals with higher OSSs tend to hold lower redistribution preferences, whereas this relationship fades away for sufficiently large values of OURs. To show the substantive implications of the proposed interaction, figure 2 compares the estimated coefficient of increasing OSSs by two standard deviations in different labor market contexts with that of other controls related to redistribution preferences.¹⁹ This is done with the binning regression used in figure 4. In addition to the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences at low and high OUR levels, which has been already analyzed in figure 4, table 2 shows the estimated difference in these associations. To put the results into context, the coefficient of the proposed interaction is comparable to

the coefficient of being female, being unemployed, or increasing years of education by two standard deviations. The association is about half as large as the association between income and redistribution preferences.

Table 2. Substantive Effects

Variable	Coefficient	95% Confidence Intervals
OSSs (low OURs)	−3.449**	[−4.465 to −2.433]
OSSs (high OURs)	−.397	[−1.846 to 1.052]
OSSs (low vs high)	−3.052**	[−4.816 to −1.288]
Income	−7.096**	[−7.694 to −6.498]
Education	−2.732**	[−3.203 to −2.056]
Unemployed	2.610**	[1.507 to 3.713]
Female	3.886**	[3.284 to 4.489]

Note. “Low OURs” refers to the median value of the lowest OUR tercile, whereas “high OURs” to the median value of its highest tercile.

* $p < .10$.

** $p < .05$.

19. It should be noted that these comparisons just assess the size of the proposed association and do not aim to compare causal magnitudes (Keele, Stevenson, and Elwert 2020).

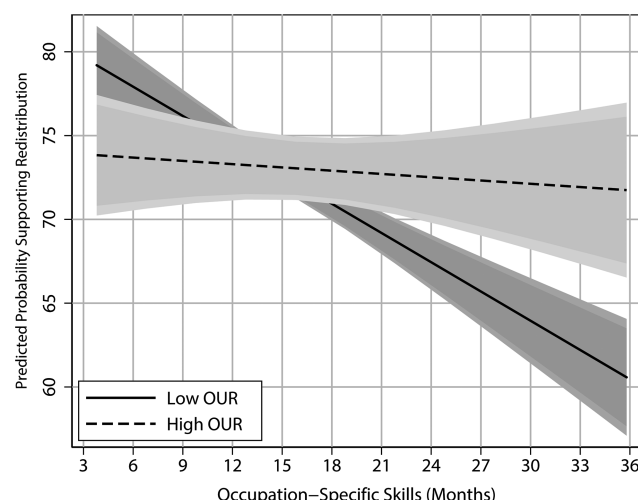


Figure 5. Probability support for redistribution by occupation-specific skills and OURs (with 95% and 90% confidence intervals). “Low OUR” refers to the median value of the lowest OURs tercile, whereas “High OUR” to the median value of its highest tercile. Gray areas are the 90%/95% confidence intervals.

As a final exercise, to intuitively get a sense of magnitude, figure 5 illustrates the differences in the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences depending on the occupational context. Specifically, it shows the relationship between the average predicted probability of supporting redistribution and OSSs in different occupational contexts. It uses the results of the binning model, setting the variables of interest to different values (i.e., OSSs and OURs) and holding the control variables at their observed values.²⁰ OURs are set to low and high values, defined as the median value of the lowest and highest tercile of OURs, respectively. When OURs are low, the 95% and 90% confidence intervals are shown in dark gray, and when OURs are high, they are displayed in light gray. The OSSs are divided into within-occupation standard deviations.

The main takeaway from this analysis is that the empirical data are consistent with the theoretical expectations, with the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences varying by occupational context. They are negatively correlated when OURs are low. For an individual with OSSs one standard deviation below the mean (value of 12), the likelihood of supporting redistribution is 74.5%, whereas for those with one standard deviation above (value of 17.5), the likelihood is 71%. The association between OSSs and redistribution is close to zero and not statistically significant when OURs are high. Moreover, figure 5 also illustrates that the occupational context

is only associated with more redistribution preferences for occupations with high levels of OSSs (Berry et al. 2012; Rehm 2009).

These analyses shed light on why the so-called middle class has such diverse redistribution preferences. Individuals with low OSSs consistently demand high levels of redistribution because of their lack of protection against unemployment and their low wage expectations. This implies that changes in the labor market context do not significantly affect their preferences. Conversely, individuals with relatively high levels of OSSs have distinct preferences depending on the labor market context. During good economic times they oppose redistribution, but during occupational downturns, they hold similar redistribution preferences to low-skilled individuals. Thus, this complements accounts that focus on the heterogeneity of preferences drawing on occupational tasks (Ares 2020; Kitschelt and Rehm 2014; Oesch 2006).

POLICY PREFERENCES

Previous analyses indicate a negative relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences that weakens when the occupational labor market deteriorates. However, economic conflict cannot simply be summarized as “more versus less welfare spending,” and it may be that there is agreement on the level of inequality but not on how this should be achieved (Häusermann and Kriesi 2015, 203). To investigate this, I use several questions on policy preferences asked in the ISSP. In doing so, I mitigate the concern that abstract questions on preferences for reducing inequality may not make clear what is at stake (Margalit and Raviv 2024). However, in this setting, respondents state their preferences for different policies without facing trade-offs among them; that is, they are in a “world of abundance” (Cavallé, Chen, and Van der Straeten 2025). For this reason, the answers show respondents’ preferences, not their preferred ranking among these policies.

As is widely acknowledged in the literature, redistributive policies pursue different objectives and target distinct population segments. Scholars usually classify these policies into two main categories: general and labor-specific policies (e.g., Gallego et al. 2022). These categories can be further subdivided. Cavallé and Trump (2015), for instance, distinguish between policies that redistribute to and those that redistribute from. Redistribution from policies, such as progressive taxation or taxation of the wealthy, emphasize the potential material benefits that individuals may gain through redistribution. Redistribution to policies, on the other hand, underscore the idea of assisting the “poor,” highlighting social-affinity motives. With regard to labor-specific policies, the literature often distinguishes between compensatory policies, which aim to mitigate the effects of job loss, and protectionist

20. To perform an exercise that resembles counterfactual variations in OSS, I use the observed values in the entire sample rather than the observed values in each tercile of OURs (Dimick, Rueda, and Stegmüller 2016).

measures, which aim to reduce the likelihood of job loss (Gallego et al. 2022).²¹

I analyze the proposed interactive effect using policies that map onto the four-type classification outlined above, distinguishing by (1) general redistribution from, (2) general redistribution to, (3) labor-specific compensatory, and (4) labor-specific protectionists. For this purpose, I use the last three rounds of the Role of Government module (1996, 2006, and 2016) of the ISSP. These rounds contain questions that capture each of these dimensions as well as consistent occupational identifiers needed for the analysis. Appendix B.2 explores the exact wording, the operationalization of the variables, their descriptive statistics, and the countries analyzed.

Specifically, the ISSP includes a battery of questions about general redistributive policies. To grasp redistribution from preferences, I use individuals' preferences for taxing the rich and a measure of preferences for tax progressivity proposed by Barnes (2015). To capture redistribution to preferences, I use a question about spending cuts (recoded to show the probability of [strongly] disagreeing) and two questions about preferences over welfare spending in retirement and health. Specifically, respondents are asked whether they would like to see more or less spending on "health" and on "old age pensions."²² Regarding protectionist labor-specific policies, the survey asks whether they believe it is the government's responsibility to fund "projects to create new jobs," to provide "jobs for all," and to support "declining industries to protect jobs." Finally, for preferences for compensatory policies, respondents are asked whether they want to see "more or less government spending" on "unemployment benefits."

Figure 6 shows the coefficient of the regression of OSSs on preferences across nine policies from the binning specification (equation 2) with the associated 95% and 90% confidence intervals. In particular, the relationship is displayed for typical individuals with low, mid, and high OUR levels, in black for policies wherein the difference between low and high levels is significant at 95% and in gray for policies wherein this is not the case. As in the main specification, the regressions include the controls defined in appendix B.2, occupation FEs at the one-digit ISCO, and country-year FEs (with ISSP weights applied).

Several findings from figure 6 are consistent with previous results on general redistribution preferences. First, across all nine policies analyzed, OSSs are not significantly associated with the probability of supporting these policies at

high OUR levels. Additionally, as anticipated, for all policies, OSSs are associated with a lower probability of supporting a redistributive policy when OURs are low than when they are high (i.e., $\hat{\alpha}_1 < \hat{\alpha}_3$). In five of these cases, the differences in the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences at low and high OUR levels are statistically significant, at least at the 95% confidence level (all except job support, unemployment benefits, retirement, and health care spending). This evidence supports the notion that OSSs are negatively correlated with preferences for redistribution when OURs are low but that this association diminishes when OURs are high.

On a more speculative note, it is intriguing to observe that the significance of these results appears to be independent of whether the policy is general or labor specific. Instead, the hypothesized relationship seems to hold for both general policies that redistribute from and specific policies that protect jobs by directly intervening in the labor market. However, for redistribution to policies, including compensatory measures, the impact appears to be less pronounced. This observation is in line with Cavaillé and Trump (2015), who emphasize the diminished importance of material self-interest for preferences over redistribution to policies.

ROBUSTNESS

To assess the sensitivity of the results, a large number of robustness tests have been performed (discussed in app. D.1). Specifically, I check whether the results are robust to (1) changes in the coding of the dependent variable, (2) changes in the variable chosen to capture OSSs, (3) changes in the variable used to grasp the occupational context, (4) changes in the controls used in the regression, (5) testing the argument against competing explanations, and (6) changes in specific countries, time periods, or occupations. I also show that the proposed relationship holds only for private workers but not for public sector workers.

Furthermore, I carry out four further exercises. First, I tentatively test the three proposed mechanisms (app. D.2). The results suggest that the moderating role of OURs is driven by the lack of skill portability and a lower association between OSSs and occupational expected wages. In a second exercise, I use different FE structures. In the most demanding specification, I exploit variations in OSSs within the same occupation-country-year in the same occupational context. Exploring further possible omitted variable bias, I employ a sensitivity analysis developed in statistics (Cinelli and Hazlett 2020). Even if the unobserved factors were six times as important as income, gender, or unemployment in determining labor market prospects and redistribution preferences, there would still be evidence of the

21. It should be noted, however, that compensatory policies, such as unemployment benefits, can be also understood as redistribution to policies (Cavaillé and Trump 2015).

22. This latter question only appears in 2016.

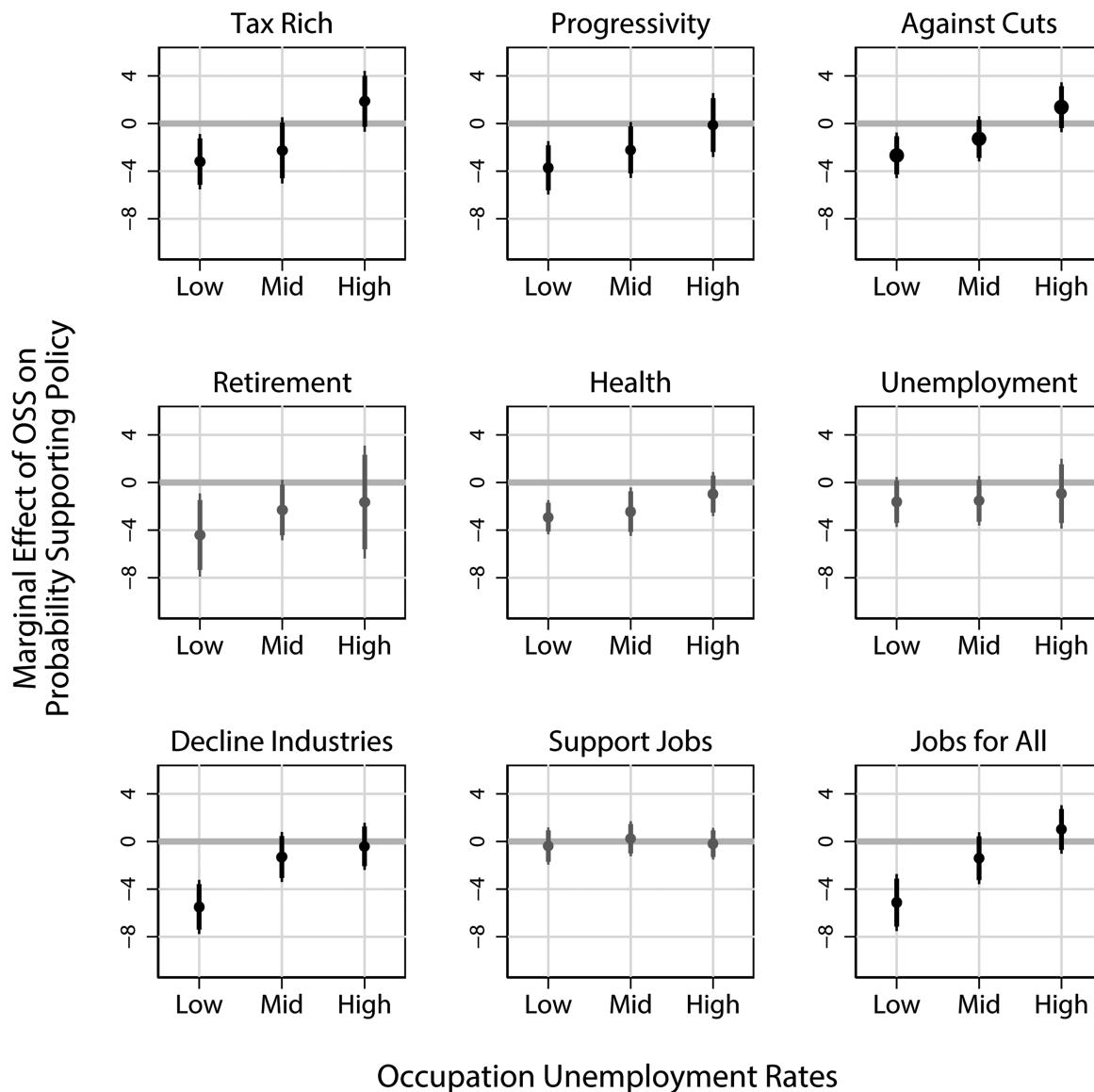


Figure 6. Support of redistributive policies: binning results. Binning estimates with 90% and 95% confidence intervals. Results are shown in black for policies wherein the difference between the coefficient at low and high occupational unemployment rates levels is significant at 95% confidence level and in gray otherwise. Standard errors clustered at country-occupation.

proposed interactive effect (app. D.3). Third, I show that the implications of this article are different from those of FSSs, vocational training, or the degree of skill specificity (app. D.4). Finally, I explore modeling assumptions, increasing the number of bins for the main regression, and relaxing the assumption about the linear relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences (app. D.5).

CONCLUSION

Recent developments in the labor market have impacted highly skilled workers in different ways, underscoring the need to comprehend their behavior in different labor market landscapes (Häusermann et al. 2015; Webb 2019; Wren and

Rehm 2014). Yet, there remains a gap in our understanding of when and why skills influence political attitudes. Specifically, this article focuses on the amount of OSSs, which have been shown to be related to vertical dimensions of social class. By integrating different perspectives that link specific skills to redistribution preferences, this study offers a microlevel explanation of how and when OSSs shape redistribution preferences.

In short, the argument suggests that in tight occupational contexts, greater OSSs increase the replaceability costs for firms. This is because it would be difficult for them to find another worker with the right skills, and hiring another worker without those skills would entail training costs. In this

scenario, two occupations with different OSSs will, on average, hold different redistribution preferences. In contrast, higher OSSs in a slack occupational context do not increase replacement costs for firms, as they can hire another worker with proper skills. In addition, the probability of changing occupation increases, with the costs of these changes being a positive function of OSSs. Thus, the greater the slack in the occupational context, the less negative the effect of OSSs on redistribution preferences.

Using the first nine rounds of the ESS, three rounds of the ISSP, and flexible interactive models, this new approach finds empirical support: In line with social mobility and insurance approaches, the association between OSSs and redistribution preferences is negative and substantially large in tight occupational contexts, but it becomes less pronounced when there is more slack in the labor market. In fact, there are no significant differences in redistributive preferences for different levels of OSSs for sufficiently slack occupational contexts.

The argument put forward bears important implications for understanding the interplay between skills and redistributive preferences. It complements recent research indicating that highly skilled workers are increasingly exposed to labor market risks, especially with the advent of artificial intelligence (Webb 2019). Furthermore, this article adds to the literature that explores the heterogeneous political preferences within the middle class. Existing studies mainly analyze horizontal dimensions of occupations focusing on work logics. For instance, they claim that skilled workers in occupations that require interpersonal contact exhibit greater preferences for redistribution compared with equally skilled workers engaged in organizational tasks (Kitschelt and Rehm 2014). Diversely, the proposed argument underscores the importance of vertical class dimensions and examines the scope conditions under which these dimensions influence redistribution preferences.

Certainly, further research should incorporate how individual or contextual factors may shape the strength of the proposed relationship. In particular, the argument could be enriched by considering the role of private insurance. Although the welfare state provides insurance, individuals can accumulate wealth to buffer against risks (Jensen and Wiedemann 2023), with access to credit having similar effects (Ahlquist and Ansell 2017). According to this body of literature, the observed effects should be more pronounced for individuals facing liquidity constraints. Because these individuals have limited opportunities to self-insure, they are more reliant on the protection of the welfare state. Incorporating such insights could enrich the argument and provide a more nuanced understanding of the relationship between OSSs and redistribution preferences.

In addition, delving into institutional factors can provide valuable insights into the dynamics observed in this study (Gingrich and Ansell 2012). From a comparative standpoint, the proposed argument departs significantly from that of *Varieties of Capitalism*, which posits that individuals predominantly acquire specific skills, rather than general skills, in institutional settings that protect the investment in these risky skills (Ahlquist and Ansell 2023; Hall and Soskice 2001). In contrast, I emphasize that OSSs are also related to firms' replaceability costs, which reduces the probability of job loss. For this reason, the reinforcement effect of institutional factors is less evident. In addition, high union density or employment regulations have a theoretically ambiguous impact on the proposed interactive effect. For example, although employment protection policies may prevent job loss, they may also hinder job creation and exacerbate problems related to the portability of skills. It is, therefore, essential to assess which of the two motives prevails in different contexts.

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